

Blood and Bruises

~ayush kumar

INT. COUNSELOR'S OFFICE – AFTERNOON

Pune. A city where rich kids drive before they can spell license. Where fathers build towers of glass and mothers argue in courts. Where teens fight not just for themselves but for family pride and money. The room is tense.

The FIRST BOY sits in a plush chair. His lip is split and cheek swollen. Designer shirt but posture defeated. He presses an ice pack to his face. Across from him the SECOND BOY sits arms crossed. Flashy shirt and chunky watch. His black eye is fresh and knuckle bloodied. He wears his wounds like badges.

Between them stands the COUNSELOR. Late thirties. File in her hand but eyes fixed on them instead. She looks tired and guilty. She divorced her husband for the First Boy's father. A secret love she still carries.

COUNSELOR

Every week it's the same. Bruises and silence and pride. You're not hurting each other. You're hurting yourselves.

SECOND BOY

Please. He's just mad because my father's buying out his dad's company.

The FIRST BOY tenses but says nothing. His eyes dart to the counselor then quickly away.

COUNSELOR

Your father. He's a good man. He built everything from nothing.

Her voice softens when she mentions him. The FIRST BOY notices.

INT. COUNSELOR'S OFFICE – CONTINUOUS

Silence stretches. Then the FIRST BOY laughs quietly. Bitter.

FIRST BOY

You don't get it. None of you. I'm done.

SECOND BOY

Done?

FIRST BOY

Fighting you. Fighting them. Fighting myself.

He throws the ice pack into the trash. His lip bleeds again.

FIRST BOY

You think this is about the company? It's not. It's about being puppets in their game.

The SECOND BOY studies him. The smirk slowly fading.

SECOND BOY

What do you mean?

FIRST BOY

Look around. We're seventeen. Fighting over stuff we didn't even choose. Your dad wants my dad's business. My mom wants me to be perfect.

COUNSELOR

Your parents love you. In their own way.

FIRST BOY

Do they? Or do they love what I represent?

The counselor's eyes show pain. She knows about complicated love.

SECOND BOY

And we beat the hell out of each other for it.

FIRST BOY

Exactly.

For the first time their eyes meet without hatred. Understanding flickers between them.

COUNSELOR

Maybe you both see it now.

She looks at the clock. Her hands tremble slightly. She knows he's coming.

INT. COUNSELOR'S OFFICE – LATER

The door creaks. The faint HUM of luxury cars outside. The FIRST BOY'S MOTHER appears first. Cold and lawyer like. Heels clicking. Eyes sharp. Behind her the FIRST BOY'S FATHER appears. Quiet and guilty. CEO from humble beginnings.

The moment he arrives the counselor's breath catches. Their eyes meet for a split second. Years of hidden feelings pass between them. He looks away first.

The SECOND BOY'S MOTHER appears next. Showy with eyes gleaming with superiority. Finally the SECOND BOY'S FATHER walks in. Confident and smug. The man trying to buy out the First Boy's father's company.

FIRST BOY'S MOTHER

Look at you. A disgrace. Do you know what this does to our name?

FIRST BOY'S FATHER

Son.

His voice is soft. Broken. The counselor watches him with caring eyes.

COUNSELOR

Mr. Sharma. Your son has been trying to tell us something important.

She uses his name gently. Like a caress. The FIRST BOY'S MOTHER notices and her eyes narrow.

FIRST BOY'S MOTHER

I think we can handle our own son's discipline.

COUNSELOR

Of course. I just meant—

FIRST BOY'S FATHER

Let her speak. She knows what she's doing.

He defends her. The FIRST BOY'S MOTHER's jaw tightens.

SECOND BOY'S FATHER

Your father built his company. Soon it'll be mine. But you? You'll remember who won today.

The FIRST BOY stands up slowly.

FIRST BOY

Actually we both lost.

The parents look confused.

SECOND BOY

He's right. We're tired of being your weapons against each other.

FIRST BOY'S MOTHER

What are you talking about?

FIRST BOY

We're not going to fight anymore. Not for you. Not for your business deals. Not for your egos.

The SECOND BOY nods.

SECOND BOY

Find another way to settle your scores. We're done being pawns.

The parents stare in shock as both boys walk toward the door.

COUNSELOR

Sometimes the children are wiser than the adults.

The FIRST BOY'S FATHER looks at her. For a moment the room fades. It's just them.

FIRST BOY'S FATHER

You always knew the right thing to say.

COUNSELOR

I wish I knew the right thing to do.

The FIRST BOY'S MOTHER steps between them.

FIRST BOY'S MOTHER

We should go. Now.

EXT. SCHOOL PARKING LOT – LATER

The boys walk out together. Still bruised but no longer enemies. Behind them the parents exit. The FIRST BOY'S FATHER lingers.

FIRST BOY'S FATHER

I'll catch up. Need to discuss something with the counselor.

FIRST BOY'S MOTHER

Make it quick.

She walks away. Suspicious.

INT. COUNSELOR'S OFFICE – MOMENTS LATER

The FIRST BOY'S FATHER returns alone. The counselor is packing files.

FIRST BOY'S FATHER

We can't keep doing this.

COUNSELOR

Meeting about your son?

FIRST BOY'S FATHER

You know what I mean.

She stops packing. Her shoulders sag.

COUNSELOR

I left my husband for you. Two years ago. And you're still with her.

FIRST BOY'S FATHER

It's complicated. The business. My son.

COUNSELOR

It's always complicated with you.

COUNSELOR

We haven't had closure. What is this? What are we?

FIRST BOY'S FATHER

Look. I can't leave my wife. I am rich. I have reputation. To be honest lonely girls like you are just playdolls for me. I just wanted physical release.

The counselor stares at him. Shocked.

FIRST BOY'S FATHER

But I care about you. If you want I can give you a flat. Nice area. You don't have to work here anymore.

COUNSELOR

A flat?

FIRST BOY'S FATHER

Yes. Think about it. No more struggling. No more dealing with problem kids like my son.

The counselor takes a breath. Her eyes fill with tears but she doesn't cry.

COUNSELOR

Get out.

FIRST BOY'S FATHER

What?

COUNSELOR

I said get out. Now.

FIRST BOY'S FATHER

You're being emotional. Think practically—

COUNSELOR

I have honor. Something you don't understand. I may be lonely but I am not your playdoll.

She walks to the door and opens it.

COUNSELOR

Leave. And don't come back unless it's about your son. Which I doubt will happen again.

He stares at her. Then shrugs.

FIRST BOY'S FATHER

Your loss.

He walks out. She closes the door behind him. Sits at her desk. Her hands shake. She covers her face with her hands.

EXT. SCHOOL PARKING LOT – CONTINUOUS

The boys are talking by their cars.

SECOND BOY

So what now?

FIRST BOY

I don't know. Be normal teenagers for once?

SECOND BOY

I forgot what that feels like.

FIRST BOY

Want to find out? Let's go for drinks tonight. Call our friends. All of them.

SECOND BOY

You mean together?

FIRST BOY

Yeah. Why not?

They shake hands then walk toward their separate rides. This time as allies not enemies. The FIRST BOY'S FATHER gets in his car. He doesn't look back.

EXT. BAR – NIGHT

Later. Music and neon. The boys laugh together with ALL their friends. Both groups mixed. Bruises hidden and everyone cheering. The FIRST BOY and SECOND BOY sit together. Friends from both sides around them.

SECOND BOY

This is weird but good weird.

FIRST BOY

Agreed.

The night goes on. More drinks. More laughter.

SECOND BOY

Taxi for him. Porsche for me.

The FIRST BOY waves. He gets pulled into a taxi by friends. The SECOND BOY jingles the Porsche keys with swagger in every step.

FRIEND

Bro you're wasted.

SECOND BOY

Relax. I was born driving.

Engine ROARS. Tires screech. VOOOOM. The Porsche vanishes into Pune night.

INT. COUNSELOR'S APARTMENT – SAME NIGHT

The counselor sits alone. Glass of wine. Looking at old photos of her wedding day. She tears one photo in half. Throws it away. Her phone buzzes. Unknown number. Text: "Flat is still available. Think about it." She blocks the number. Deletes the message.

INT. MIDDLE-CLASS HOME – NIGHT

A small flat. Parents and two kids huddle around a TV. Dinner plates on floor. On TV a NEWS REPORTER speaks.

NEWS REPORTER (ON TV)

Breaking news from Pune. A 17 year old driving a Porsche crashed into two motorbike riders late last night. Both victims died on the spot.

The family stares. Silence.

INT. COUNSELOR'S APARTMENT – SAME NIGHT

The counselor sees the news. She recognizes the boy from the photo. She covers her mouth. Then she cries. Not for him. For herself. For all of it.

MONTAGE – TV NEWS REPORTS

— ONE WEEK LATER —

NEWS REPORTER (ON TV) Public outrage grows as the minor walks free on bail. Critics say the rich bend Pune's rules to their favor.

— TWO WEEKS LATER —

NEWS REPORTER (ON TV) Protests outside the courthouse demand justice. The Porsche case sparks debate on privilege and underage driving.

— THREE WEEKS LATER —

NEWS REPORTER (ON TV) The teenager has become infamous nationwide. Families of the victims demand accountability.

EXT. PUNE SKYLINE – SUNSET

Camera glides over towers. Golden light on glass. Traffic moves slower. People walk with purpose.

VOICEOVER

Pune. City of dreams and broken promises. Where boys become men too early and women learn to stand alone. Where one night changes everything and nothing ever really changes at all.

FADE OUT.

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